1954 U Nu stated: ‘The Rohingya has the equal status of nationality with Kachin, Kayah, Karen, Mon, Rakhine and Shan’.[91] A radio station was established that broadcast using their dialect[92] and the legislation setting this up makes direct reference to Rohingya as one of the minority languages needing to be reflected in the diversity of broadcasting.

It is not clear why the Rohingyas were singled out. There was anti-Muslim sentiment arising from the British having sometimes preferred Muslims over Buddhists, and having facilitated Indian immigration into the region, which caused some locals to struggle to find employment. But other Muslim ethnicities, both in Rakhine and the rest of Burma, were granted full citizenship. The 1947 revolt and the decision in 1948 to petition for inclusion in East Pakistan did not help but were minor events compared to the revolts by the Shan and Karen (both of whom were on the list of accepted ethnicities). One argument is that even before independence, the issue of migration from India was a source of irritation to the Burmese majority. There was some truth in their concerns: Baxter’s 1941 report noted there had been labour substitution[93] arising from migration from India in three areas: the docks, the recently established rice fields and rubber plantations, and the civil service. However, the Rohingyas, being mainly engaged in agriculture and fishing in their own village communities, had not been present in these roles.

The 1947 Constitution formally acknowledged that all ethnic groups in Burma were immigrants[94] and that the differential treatment of the Rohingyas would be subsequently addressed. In particular, it was intended that citizenship would be granted on the basis of having lived in the territory of Burma for at least eight out of the previous ten years. As a result, Article 11 (iv) of the constitution awarded the Rohingyas National Registration Certificates with full legal and voting rights.[95] The Rohingyas were told they had no need to apply for a citizenship certificate ‘as you are one of the indigenous races of the Union of Burma’[96] (see Appendix 3).

The wider evidence is that in the 1950s the Rohingyas were acknowledged to be a separate ethnic group, part of the complex pattern of ethnicities in Burma, and relatively well integrated into Burmese political and social systems. In the period between 1948 and 1961 a small number of Rohingyas (between four and six) were serving as members of parliament, and even after the military coup several Rohingyas remained in parliament